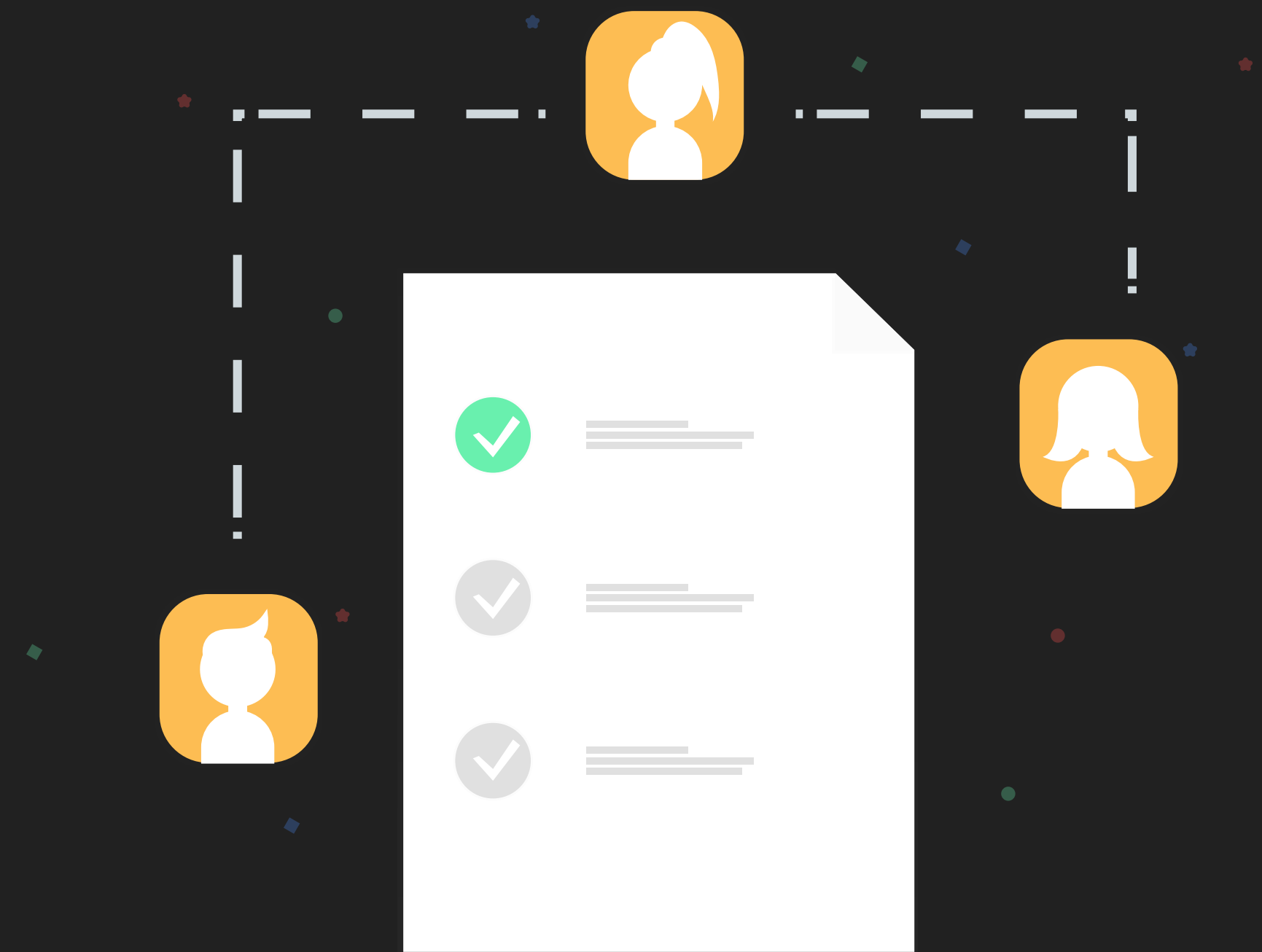




The Ultimate Guide to Remote Product Management in 2020

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Introduction

Why Remote Product Management?

A growing number of workers are experiencing and expecting remote organizations. In the [State of Remote Work report 2020](#), Buffer surveyed over 3,500 workers from around the world: 98% expected to work remotely in their career and 97% would recommend remote work to others. This is all the more true for software engineers and designers, who account for almost half of all remote jobs posted on [AngelList](#). Remote engineers and designers naturally require a remote product organization, and product managers need to adapt to this fundamental shift in the way people collaborate at work.

Product managers are social by essence. They work with executives to set objectives and build the roadmap. They collect requirements from customer-facing teams. They iterate on specifications with designers and engineers. While collaboration and communication are at the heart of

product management, they are also the top challenges in remote organizations. That being said, working as a remote organization can also become an invaluable advantage for product teams. Remote work encourages transparency, crystal clear communication and discipline in execution, which are essential for successful product management.

As remote work is the norm at Harvestr, our team has experimented and learned a lot about remote collaboration, processes and tools. In this guide, we are sharing our own learnings along with some industry best-practices on how to run a remote product team. We will walk through multiple aspects of remote product management and offer some examples from inspiring remote product teams.

Foundations for a remote product culture

Remote is a culture as much as it is a way of collaborating. Running a remote product team requires some fundamental principles that will shape the way product managers, their teams and their stakeholders work together. Transparency, communication and autonomy should be at the core of your remote product culture.

Full transparency on the product roadmap

When distance naturally creates misalignment, giving all stakeholders full transparency on the product roadmap is even more critical. Remote product teams need to ensure that everyone in the company can get access to a clear and up-to-date picture of where the product is right now, and where it is going in a foreseeable future.

The roadmap is not only a guide for the product team, but for the company as a whole. Marketing refers to the roadmap to prepare campaigns. Salespeople rely on the roadmap to sell features and close deals. Designers anticipate research and discovery based on product priorities. When all these stakeholders and the product team are not colocated, when they are not working on the same time zones, they need a single source of truth where they will find all the information they need about where the product is going. The level of transparency of your product roadmap will have a direct impact on the efficiency of other teams, and on the success of their own projects.

A transparent roadmap does not only set a list of clearly defined priorities on a more or less precise time frame. A transparent roadmap should also give clarity on the product vision, on the business strategy and on the current product goals. Bringing full transparency on these critical components of the roadmap will help product teams align the whole company on the priorities they have defined.

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You'll have to adopt a level of transparency that feels uncomfortable at first, so everyone feels connected with the business.

Nick Francis

Co-founder and CEO of HelpScout

Over-communicate from Discovery to Delivery

Product teams are made of functions and roles that heavily rely on each other. Product managers define problems and set priorities, designers frame solutions, and engineers turn specifications into working software. Therefore, successful remote product teams are the ones who will be able to implement a flawless communication flow from Discovery to Delivery. To avoid blockers and to make sure that everyone gets the right information when they need it, remote product managers must advocate for over-communication.

#1

Communication is the number one challenge for remote workers according to [The Remote Work Report 2019 from FYI](#)

At Harvestr, we use Slack as our primary mode of communication. To make our lives easier, a considerable part of our own communication relies on integrations and automations. We have bots for announcing new trials, sharing customer feedback, communicating on feature releases and bug fixes. This helps us remove part of the burden of writing everything down, while making sure that everyone is aware of important product information.

Over-communication is not only about communicating more, it is also about communicating better. In remote teams, customer problems need to be

documented in detail, priorities and deadlines need to be clearly set, and feature specifications should leave no space for doubt. A particular attention should be given to how the product knowledge is documented and communicated during the Discovery phase: a problem that is not accurately framed and contextualized from the very beginning will put designers and developers on the wrong track. For this reason, it is crucial for remote product teams to intensify communication during the early stages of the Discovery process and make sure that all stakeholders work in the same direction.

Buffer's 10 Slack Agreements

Implementing rules for communication is the best way to make it work. Buffer created a list of 10 agreements to help their teams communicate efficiently on Slack. These rules include recommendations on proactive communication, being focused, providing regular answers to teammates who need it, and having a healthy work/life balance.

Optimize for autonomy and discipline

Remote product management has to cope with cross-functional teams who need to collaborate efficiently although they are working asynchronously. Such an organization requires a high degree of autonomy from all stakeholders, who, at the same time, must all work towards common goals.

To make coworkers fully autonomous, remote product teams should focus on results versus time spent. Teammates should be given a mission with an objective, and then have full autonomy to set their own roadmap to success. Limiting dependencies between teams will help them move faster and prevent blocking situations.

Autonomy is also synonymous with discipline. Remote product managers, designers and engineers are all part of the same value chain. This value chain will only work if the right information is available for the right person at the right time. Designers should not be blocked because they are waiting for Product Managers to define priorities. Developers should not be blocked because they are waiting for a missing functional requirement.

That is why having a strict discipline for deadlines and commitments is key to the success of remote product teams.

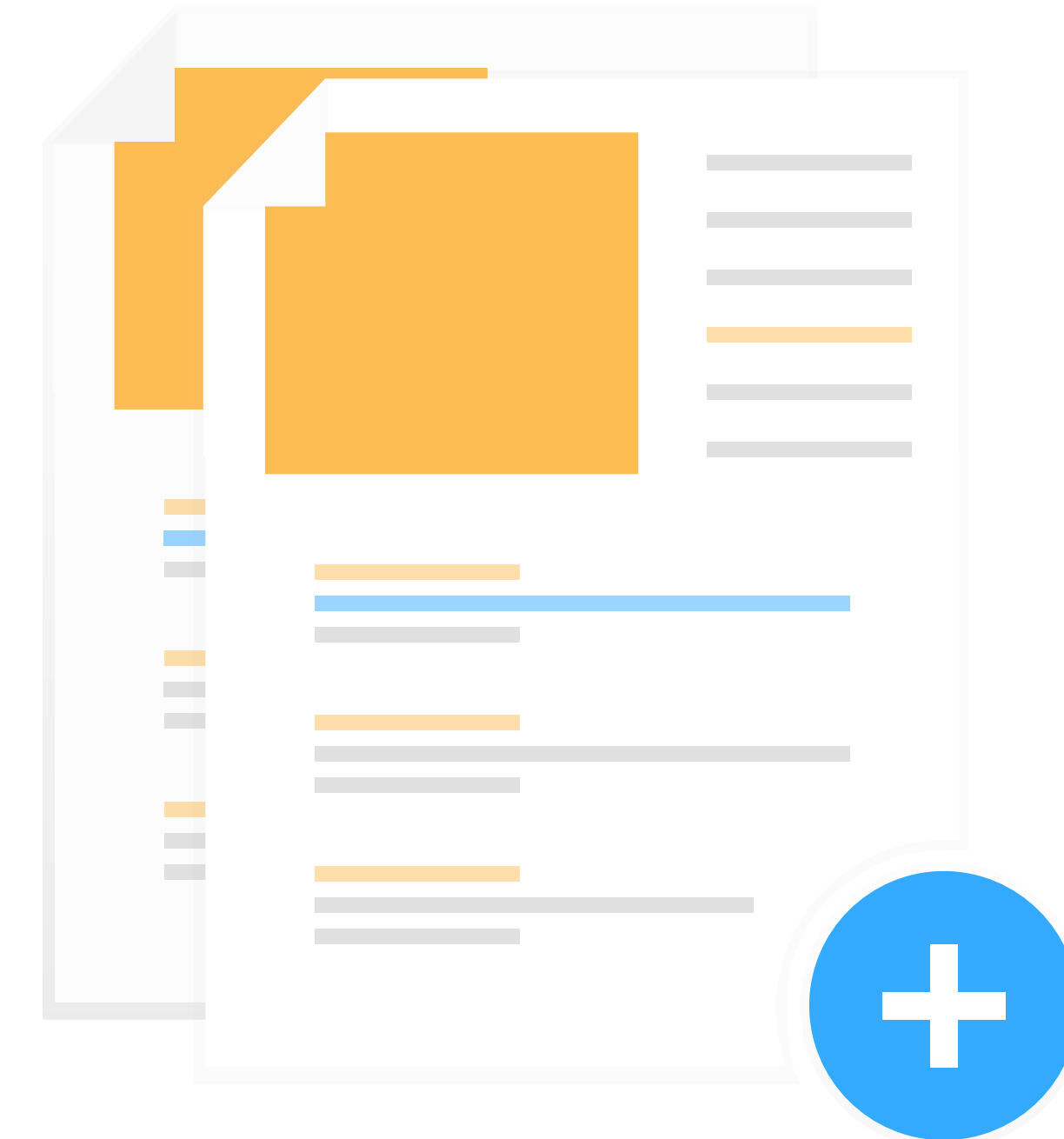
Building a robust remote product organization from Discovery to Delivery

Write your Product Playbook

To put the principles of transparency and communication into practice, remote product teams need a central place where they can document the most important components of their product management process. At Harvestr, we call it the Product Playbook. This playbook should serve as a single source of truth that will minimize confusion about what your product is about, your strategy, and how remote teammates should work and collaborate. Its purpose is not only to serve product teams, but rather to be a reference for the whole company. Therefore, your Product Playbook should always be accessible and it should be updated regularly.

Key items to include in your Product Playbook

- Product vision, strategy and objectives
- Personas and main problems you are solving
- Product features and benefits
- Discovery, prioritization and Delivery processes
- Product templates (user interviews, PRDs, user stories, product meetings...)



A well documented Product Playbook is essential to align remote product teams and make sure everyone is working in the same direction. Writing all these things down will also be a time-saver and minimize unnecessary discussions about how things should be done all along the product development process. Last but not least, your Product Playbook will also be the perfect starting point for new remote employees to get onboarded as fast as possible.

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I think documentation has to be instilled as a value. It has to start there, and the whole leadership team in an organization has to be onboard. All of leadership needs to understand the importance of documentation — not just with lip service. A true, genuine understanding of its value.

Gabe W.

Senior Product Manager, GitLab

A single source of truth for your product roadmap

One of the main issues faced by remote product teams is inefficient access to information. Salespeople need to know about the status of their customers' requests, product managers need to know if designs are ready for review, and basically everyone needs information from someone else. In remote organizations, coworkers cannot come to each others' desks and ask about updates and statuses. In some cases, remote organizations will not only have to cope with distance, but also with different time zones.

In this context, your product roadmap should be the primary point of entry for anyone who is looking for information about a specific product project. Product roadmaps are perfect to play this role, precisely because they are meant to be a communication medium that speaks to everyone. Roadmaps are not too technical for business people, and they should not be only goal and business-oriented either. Roadmaps give the direction by presenting what will be done and when.

To play this central role, remote product roadmaps cannot just be about vague projects on a timeline. They should also inform other stakeholders about why some projects are prioritized, and why others are not. Providing this context will prevent back and forths that would create frustration and friction in a context where people work asynchronously. Last but not least, remote product roadmaps will only be a relevant point of entry if they are always up to date and easily accessible for everyone in the company.

Key characteristics of a remote product roadmap

Present the what, the when and the why

Give context on why you are prioritizing specific projects and provide estimates.

Point of entry to find product information

Organize product information to make it searchable from a single point of entry.

Accessible by everyone from everywhere

Make it easy for everyone to find and explore the roadmap when they need it.

Always up-to-date

Make sure your teammates always have access to the most recent version of the roadmap.

Transparently share customer insights during Product Discovery

Product management starts with a customer problem that needs to be solved. Framing, scoping and documenting this problem is essential to make sure that the whole product value chain will be working on something meaningful, and in the right direction. In a remote context where transparency, communication and autonomy are key, a special attention should therefore be given to how the Product Discovery phase is documented and processed.

Remote product teams should start by creating a template for how customer problems should be framed and documented. A good practice is to have a page or document per problem, that will centralize all the knowledge accumulated during the Discovery phase. This document should be made accessible for all relevant stakeholders, who will be able to add their own insights all along the process.

Remote product teams need to make sure that customer knowledge is always available and shared during this Discovery phase. Having a central place where team members can get access to customer feedback and insights will help them work autonomously. It will also make sure that the whole team has a unified understanding of how customers engage with a product, and what can actually be improved.

Like with roadmaps, remote teams need to make sure that their whole Discovery documentation is easily searchable when someone needs it.

Zapier's "User Study Theatre" for remote design

In addition to tying customer feedback to discovery problems that are being worked on, teams should also collaborate in collecting and analyzing this feedback. The Zapier remote design team came up with what they call the "[User Study Theatre](#)". It is a Slack bot that informs teammates when a user research session is planned. It encourages other people to join the session if they wish to. The User Study Theatre is an efficient way to share customer knowledge within the design team and collaborate on customer problems during the discovery process.

Implement a state-of-the-art feedback loop

When product and customer-facing teams are working remotely, there has to be an efficient way for the latter to escalate requirements and get updates in return. We saw how communication can be challenging in a remote environment. Therefore, remote product organizations need to make sure that no insights or requirements get lost in the various tools and systems used by the company.

First, customer-facing teams should give as much context as possible on the problems they escalate to the product team. Why does a customer need this feature? What is he trying to achieve? What is the use case? How important is it for the customer? Is it a deal-breaker or not? These are all valuable insights that must be conveyed to the product team and summarized in a requirement template.

Once the escalation process and format are in place, remote product teams need a system to keep track of requests and review them regularly. They should build a dashboard that will gather the full list of requirements. This dashboard will provide the product team with a regularly updated source of truth around the user experience. To make things organized and searchable, items can be grouped by product, feature, customer segment, and urgency for example.

Closing the loop and following up with teammates on their requests should be the last step of this process. Just like for the remote product roadmap, customer-facing teams need a place where they can follow the status of their requests and review the plan. Product teams should be as precise as they can on statuses and commit on dates whenever possible.

Harvestr

Building a state-of-the art customer feedback loop is something that [Harvestr](#) can help you with. Harvestr comes with a feedback hub that integrates with all your internal and external feedback channels (customer support tools, CRMs, surveys, Slack...). It makes it easy for customers and teammates to escalate feedback to the product team, and make sure that you are building customer-centric products.

Build a shared prioritization framework for product decisions

Making remote product management work requires consistent alignment on roadmap priorities. These priorities should be clearly defined in your Product Playbook and visible on your shared roadmap. All stakeholders must know what matters the most at a given time. Working as a remote product organization also requires alignment on the why of priorities. Why are we building this now and not next year? Why are we prioritizing this customer request and not that one? To avoid back and forths and potential conflicts, the product team needs to align the whole company on a structured prioritization process. This framework should be specific to each product and company, and it should explain the reasons behind each decision.

Delivering great customer experience and increasing usage should not be the only criteria that drive product decisions. Sales and business KPIs should be part of the process too, in order to make sure that new features do not only contribute to the success of the product, but to the success of the company as a whole. Here are some examples of criteria that can be used to evaluate product opportunities in a transparent and unified way:

- How many customers escalated the problem?
- How many customers are impacted in total ?
- Since when has it been a problem?
- What type of customers are impacted?
- How important is this to them? Must-have, nice-to-have, deal-breaker?
- Did we lose any customer because of this?
- How much extra revenue could we generate with this feature?
- To what extent will it impact product usage?

In remote product teams, these criteria need to be agreed upon and communicated to all stakeholders. They will service as a reference during product and roadmap meetings, and help rationalize product decisions at the company level.

Set regular product meetings

By making meetings more difficult to organize, remote work incites companies to focus on the most important ones. In remote product teams, it is all the more important to have regular meetings, since product management involves a high degree of social interaction and collaboration. Meetings also foster team alignment and help reduce social distancing. Here is a list of meetings that can help remote product teams structure collaboration and communication while working from distance.

Weekly product check-ins

Syncing up with your team members every Monday is a good way to start the week together. These meetings should be an opportunity to debrief on what has been done the week before, and give each other some visibility on what will be done this week. Showing progress will increase motivation. Presenting the plan helps build transparency and alignment. When everyone knows what everyone is doing, people know where they will find the information they need and who they should talk to if they have questions.

The Product Pitch

The Product Pitch meeting takes place when the product team starts working on new problems or feature ideas. They should of course include the product team, but also stakeholders from customer-facing teams who can bring some additional context and ideas. During this kickoff meeting, the product team will basically present a detailed Product Requirements Document that contains: the problem, the data behind the problem and why it matters, some solutions and an estimated schedule for building those solutions. When inviting people from other teams like support and sales, requirements and solutions can be challenged to identify potential blind spots. It also aligns everyone on what the product team is working on and prevents unnecessary back and forths.

The Product Demo Day

The Product Demo day is the counterpart of the Product Pitch meeting: it is an opportunity for the product team to present new features that about to be released. They would also explain how these features are solving the problems that were identified in the beginning. Feedback and questions from the audience will help product managers identify remaining blind spots, and make ultimate modifications before releasing the features to customers.

For each of these product meetings, managers should of course set the conditions for success by sending out goals, agendas and relevant materials upfront. Each meeting should also end up with a shared recap of the main take-aways and some actionable next steps to follow up on.

Systematize product communication

We have seen to what extent over-communication was one of the key principles for a successful remote product culture. Over-communication must be a standard within the product team, but also towards the rest of the company. However, communicating takes time and it may first be interpreted as an unnecessary task, especially by people who are not used to remote working. To prevent insufficient communication, product teams should automate it as much as possible, especially when it comes to updating people on statuses and releases.

Here are some practical examples of updates that product teams can automate to make communication easier and more transparent.

Roadmap updates

Record roadmap updates in real time and make them available for your teammates. Explain your decisions and commit on dates whenever possible.

Customer feedback feed

Centralize all incoming customer feedback in one unique feed to share customer knowledge and encourage customer-driven product thinking.

Project kickoff announcement

Share all your Product Requirements Documents with the whole team. It will bring visibility and align teams on what is being worked on.

Bugs & feature releases

Make sure you have a single place where you communicate bugs and features releases, in order to keep everyone in the loop.

With the right set of tools, remote product teams should be able to automate most of this communication, which will help them save time while still being as transparent as possible.

Discipline and autonomy for successful remote product delivery

In remote teams, the product delivery phase can be the source of many hurdles if it is not prepared with a high degree of discipline and attention to details. The handoff between product and engineers is a critical step that can trigger the success or failure of a new feature. This is all the more true for teams who work from distance and asynchronously.

To avoid back and forths, impromptu meetings and frustrations, product teams first need to anticipate and prevent blockers. The worst thing that can happen in the middle of a sprint, is having something or someone slowing down delivery. If successive blockers appear at a large scale with several product teams working together, this will eventually impact the whole product roadmap, which in turn, will impact other departments.

Remote product teams should always dedicate special efforts to identify and minimize blockers. Most of the time, blockers will either be about missing information or missing authorization. In addition to thorough planning and regular check-ins, an efficient way to prevent blocking situations is to actually empower all stakeholders to remove blockers themselves. This means giving engineers a high amount of autonomy on how they organize their work to meet the objectives and requirements.

We have built a to-do list that will help you make sure a project is ready to be handed to your remote engineers for delivery:

- The Product Requirements Document has been validated with engineers

- Open questions have been answered, potential blockers were identified
- Engineers have defined tasks and set priorities themselves
- Expectations and success have been clearly defined

When product and engineering teams are working autonomously, the focus has to be on result and not on time spent. For this reason, successful delivery highly depends on the ability to build clear deliverables and set reasonable expectations.

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It's about results, not where your IP address is.

Mark Frein

Chief People Officer, InVision

Build your remote organization as a product

Remote implies new ways of working as a team and this kind of shift does not happen by itself. Companies should therefore think about their remote organizations just like they think about building a product.

They should start by investigating the main issues faced by coworkers when they are working remotely, and design solutions to give their teams a better working environment. Engaging people in building their own work organizations is the most natural way to build the right organization.

What are the main remote life problems?

Ryan Hoover from Produchunt conducted a [survey on Twitter](#) to identify the main problems faced by remote workers: loneliness, disconnecting, distractions, communication, water-cooler serendipity, and respect.

These problems can be a starting point to identify improvement opportunities in your remote product organization. To go further, product teams should do what they do best: talking to users (their coworkers) to understand how they can build the right remote product setup.

We have built a list of questions product teams can ask to identify improvement opportunities in their remote organizations.

What do you like and dislike most about working remotely?

How does a remote organization positively / negatively impact your work?

How does a remote organization positively / negatively impact your morale?

How can your manager and teammates best support you while working remotely?

Among your teammates, who do you depend on the most to make good progress on your work?

What tools are you using the most and how often do you use them?

When working remotely, what tools do you like using the most and why?

Once you have identified some worth-solving problems, build a roadmap, assign some resources and start building a state-of-the art remote organization for your team!

Make sure you organize regular health-checks to see how your remote organization is performing, identify new bottlenecks, and solve them right away.

Conclusion

Remote Product Management is here to stay.

Remote working is here to stay and offering a remote working environment could even become necessary to attract top product talent. According to Gallup, “[54% of office workers say they'd leave their job for one that offers flexible work time](#)”. Product teams must adapt to this new way of working by building the tools and processes that will help them be successful, no matter if they are remote or collocated.

As stated by Jason Fried from Basecamp in [Shape Up](#), “*The way a team works has an enormous influence on what it can do. The process, the methods, the practices, the approach, the discipline, the trust, the communication style, the pace. The way—the how—is foundational and fundamental*”. In this perspective, building a remote product organization should be taken more as an opportunity than a threat. An opportunity to implement clear and concise communication, higher transparency, and

increased autonomy, which will all positively contribute to product success.

At Harvestr, we consider our remote organization like a product that is solving problems in the way we work. Like with any other product, companies should keep iterating on their remote organization and make sure it is improving the everyday life of its main users: employees. We have tried to give you some valuable insights and processes that should help you build and improve your own remote product organization. We hope that this guide will be useful and we would be very happy to get your feedback and questions. If you want to share your thoughts with us, or simply want to know more about Harvestr’s approach to remote product management, feel free to reach out to us at contact@harvestr.io

Thank you for reading this guide.

The Harvestr team.



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